During the India–Pakistan war in 1971, the USSR took a firm position in favour of India and sent ships to the Indian Ocean to counter any move by the USA, which had already sent its 7th Fleet into the Bay of Bengal. The results of the 1971 India–Pakistan war and emergence of Bangladesh established a trusted partnership between India and the USSR.

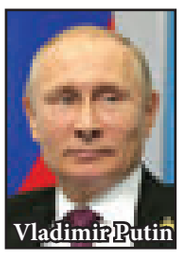
India-Russian Relations (1991-present)

With the fall of the USSR in 1991, bilateral relations between Russia and India went through a period of uncertainty. The Treaty of 1971 became ineffective as the Soviet regime no longer existed. Russia was also pressed to shift its focus towards domestic affairs and its relations with the USA and Europe. India now had to deal with a Russia which did not have an interest nor the resources for developing its ties with other nations.

During his visit to New Delhi in 1993, the Russian President Boris Yeltsin signed a new Treaty of Friendship which was an effort to rekindle the spirit in which the 1971 Treaty was signed. However, the fundamental character of the Treaty was transformed as the new Treaty just called for regular consultation and coordination in case of any threat to peace. Unlike in the Soviet era, Yeltsin described India as a 'natural partner' but he did not give the impression of a 'special relationship'. Though the relationship continued between the two countries in the early 1990s, the 'benign neglect' of India by Russia in this period was evident.


Joseph Stalin


Boris Yeltsin


Vladimir Putin

Deal for S-400 Air Defence System

India and Russia have formally inked the $ 5.2 billion deal for S-400 system in the year 2018.The air defence system is expected to be delivered by the year 2020. 400 Triumf is an advanced surface-to-air missile system, developed by Russia's state-owned company Almaz-Antey, and can shoot down hostile aircraft and ballistic missiles. It has an estimated range of 250 kilometres and a possible upgrade is speculated to extend it to 400 kilometres.

The new Russian leadership under Vladimir Putin (President, 2000–present) reversed the Yeltsin-era drift in India-Russia bilateral relations. Russia signed the Declaration on Strategic Partnership with India in 2000 and established the institution of annual summit meetings. Its declaration was further elevated to the level of "Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership" in 2010. Moscow realized that as a Eurasian power, an active Russian role in an emerging Asia would be limited without a solid partnership with old friends like India.

Areas of Cooperation

Currently, India is the largest importer of Russian defence equipment. The defence facet of the relationship is one of the strongest pillars of the India-Russia relationship and has gone through the test of time. Russia is also the only country that lays emphasis on sharing high-end defence technology with India which highlights the mutual trust between the two countries.

India, Russia and other neighbouring countries are engaged in efforts to operationalise the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) which promises to propel connectivity and trade relations between the two countries.

12th_Political Science_Unit_9.indd 194 1/30/2020 3:43:59 PM